

A Christmas Carol

Charles Dickens · plot, characters, themes · for the September test

Edition on Classroom: Black Cat 2003, adapted by Peter Foreman — 6 chapters (the original novel has 5 “Staves”). Exercises in the reader are optional. Manfreda will test the reading: plot, characters, themes. These notes follow this PDF.

In 30 seconds

Christmas Eve, Victorian London. Ebenezer Scrooge is a rich, cold miser. He hates Christmas, pays clerk Bob Cratchit almost nothing, refuses charity, and insults his kind nephew Fred. That night the ghost of partner Jacob Marley (dead seven years) appears in chains: he loved only money. Three spirits will visit Scrooge. The Ghost of Christmas Past shows a lonely childhood, generous boss Fezziwig, and fiancée Belle, lost because Scrooge preferred money. The Ghost of Christmas Present shows the poor but loving Cratchits and sick Tiny Tim, then Fred’s happy party. The Ghost of Christmas Yet To Come shows a future where Scrooge dies hated and alone, and Tiny Tim dies too. Scrooge begs to change. He wakes on Christmas morning, gives to the poor, sends a turkey to the Cratchits, dines with Fred, raises Bob’s salary, and becomes a second father to Tiny Tim. Tiny Tim does not die.

One sentence: Dickens attacks Victorian greed and shows that a man can still change if he opens his heart to other people.

Dickens and context

Charles Dickens (1812–1870), born in Portsea; family moved to London. At 12 he worked in a factory; later his parents went to prison for debt. He never forgot this. Reporter, then novelist (Oliver Twist, David Copperfield, Hard Times, Great Expectations...). He attacked materialism, poverty and social injustice. A Christmas Carol (1843) is the most famous Christmas story in the world. Buried in Westminster Abbey.

Victorian London: crowded, foggy, dirty. The poor faced workhouses and prison for debt; children worked in factories. For Dickens, Christmas is when people should open their hearts. True “business” is people, charity, love — not only profit.

Characters

Who	Role
Ebenezer Scrooge	Protagonist. Old, mean, cold miser. Changes completely after the three spirits.
Jacob Marley	Dead partner (7 years, Christmas Eve). Ghost in chains. Comes to warn Scrooge.
Bob Cratchit	Clerk. Poor, kind, patient. Tiny fire at work. Loves Tiny Tim.
Tiny Tim	Bob’s little son. Crutch. “God bless everyone!” Dies if the future does not change; in the end he lives.
Mrs Cratchit	Proud, hard-working. Does not want to drink to Scrooge (hard old miser).
Belinda, Peter, Martha	Cratchit children. Martha is the oldest (works); Peter helps at home.
Fred	Nephew, son of sister Fanny. Warm, generous; invites Scrooge every year.
Fred’s wife	Thinks Scrooge is stupid and bad; still celebrates with Fred.
Two gentlemen	Collect for the poor. Scrooge gives nothing, then a large gift on Christmas Day.
Fanny	Scrooge’s sister (Past). Fetches him home from school. Dies; her child is Fred.
Mr Fezziwig	Old employer. Happy, generous Christmas party. Happiness “like a fortune”.
Belle	Fiancée. Leaves him because he loves money more. Later: happy family.
Old Joe	In the future: buys things stolen from the dead miser’s house.
Cleaning woman / housekeeper	Steal curtains, blankets, funeral shirt, sheets after he dies alone.

The four ghosts

Ghost	Looks like	Lesson
Marley	Chain of cash-boxes, keys, account books; handkerchief round the head	Selfish life → chains after death. Three spirits = last hope.
Christmas Past	Child and old man; white hair; flowers; holly	Memory: he was not always cold. He chose money over love.
Christmas Present	Kind giant, torch, holly, 1,800+ brothers; dies at midnight	Now: the Cratchits’ love; Tiny Tim; society’s starving children.
Yet To Come	Tall, silent, black hood; never speaks	Future if he does not change: hated death; Tim dies. Future can still change.

Chapter 1 — Scrooge

Christmas Eve. Marley is dead — Scrooge was at the funeral and even looked happy because he made money that day. Years later the sign is still Scrooge and Marley. Scrooge is mean, cold, solitary. The cold is inside him (eyes, voice, office). Nobody greets him; dogs run away. He doesn’t care. He likes it.

Fog, already dark at three. Clerk Bob Cratchit copies letters by a tiny fire; he tries to warm his hands at a candle. Nephew Fred: “A merry Christmas!” Scrooge: “Bah! Humbug!” Fred is poor but merry; Scrooge is rich but unhappy. Fred: Christmas is the only time people open their hearts and help each other — “God bless it!” Bob claps; Scrooge threatens to fire him. Fred invites him to dinner; Scrooge refuses. Why marry? “Because I fell in love.” For Scrooge that is more stupid than Christmas. Fred still wishes him well; Scrooge only says “Good afternoon.”

Two gentlemen collect for the poor. Scrooge: “Aren’t there any prisons? ... workhouses?” He gives nothing — he will not pay “lazy people.” If they die in the cold, there are too many people already, so that is a good thing. A carol boy is shouted away. Bob wants Christmas Day off; Scrooge agrees only if he comes extra early on the 26th. Bob dances home.

“Bah! Humbug!” · prisons / workhouses · “too many people... that’s a good thing.”

WHAT TO SAY

No ghosts yet. Chapter 1 shows why Scrooge must change: he has closed his heart to family, to the poor, and even to a child singing. Irony: the rich man is unhappy; the poor clerk dances home.

Chapter 2 — Marley’s Ghost

Home: old dark rooms. The knocker becomes Marley’s face, then a knocker again. Bells ring. The Ghost enters with a chain of cash-boxes, keys, account books. Scrooge pretends it is a bad stomach. The Ghost shakes the chain; Scrooge must believe.

If you stay away from people in life, after death you walk the world but cannot share their happiness. Marley made the chain himself: he loved only money. Scrooge’s chain is already longer and heavier than seven years ago. In life Marley never left the office — a prisoner of money; now he must travel for ever, with no rest.

Scrooge: you were a good man of business. Marley: “My business was people, my business was charity, my business was love, my business was goodness!” He lived with his eyes closed. But there is still hope: three Ghosts — first at one o’clock; second the next night at the same time; third at midnight the night after. Outside, chained ghosts cry; an old ghost with a money-box cannot help a homeless woman and baby. Scrooge starts to say “Humbug!” — and stops.

WHAT TO SAY

Marley is Scrooge’s double: the future if he does not change. The chain = selfish acts. True business is human responsibility. The three spirits are a last chance, not only a punishment.

Chapter 3 — The First Spirit (Christmas Past)

At one o’clock: a being like a child and an old man, white hair, young face, white clothes with summer flowers, holly. Ghost of Christmas Past — his past — come to help him. They pass through the wall.

School. Snowy country of his childhood. Boys shout Merry Christmas (only shadows). One child is left, with no friends: little Scrooge reading by a small fire. Adult Scrooge cries. He remembers the carol boy he sent away — first regret.

Fanny. His little sister fetches him home: Father is kinder now. The Ghost: Fanny had a good heart; when she died she left Fred. Scrooge feels bad about yesterday.

Fezziwig. Young Ebenezer and friend Dick; fat happy boss stops work on Christmas Eve. Violin, dances, food, “Merry Christmas!” at eleven. The Ghost: the party cost only three or four pounds. Scrooge: Fezziwig could make them happy or unhappy — that happiness was like a fortune. He wishes he could speak to Bob now.

Belle. Scrooge about forty; passion for money on his face. Belle cries: he loves money more than her; he is afraid of life. She sets him free. Last scene: Belle’s happy family, noisy children, presents. Husband saw lonely Scrooge at the office; Marley is dying. The past cannot be changed. Scrooge cannot watch. The Spirit vanishes.

WHAT TO SAY

The first spirit does not accuse; it shows. Lonely child □ generous Fezziwig □ Belle lost to gold. He already knows he is the opposite of Fezziwig as a boss. Memory explains the miser.

Chapter 4 — The Second Spirit (Christmas Present)

A giant with a torch, holly, kind eyes; the room is full of food and greenery. More than 1,800 brothers (one Christmas each year); he dies at midnight. Scrooge: “I learnt a good lesson last night.” Streets on Christmas morning: snow, bells, poor people taking geese to the baker’s (no oven at home). The torch makes dinners extra good.

The Cratchits. Mrs Cratchit, Belinda, Peter, Martha; Bob with Tiny Tim on his shoulder (crutch). Small goose, small pudding — they call them wonderful and eat every bit. Tiny Tim: “God bless everyone!” Scrooge: will he live? Ghost: empty chair, crutch, no Tim — if the future does not change, the child will die. Then Scrooge’s own words: too many people in the world. Wicked words. Perhaps Scrooge is worse in God’s eyes than this child. Bob drinks to Scrooge; Mrs Cratchit hates it, drinks only because it is Christmas. They are poor but contented. Scrooge watches Tiny Tim.

Fred’s party. Fred laughs at “humbug” but is sorry for his uncle — rich, yet he never laughs or helps. He will invite him every year. Game of twenty questions: the answer is Uncle Scrooge. Scrooge wants to wish them Merry Christmas; the scene vanishes.

Two children under the Spirit’s coat: thin, hungry, ugly like monsters. “Are they yours?” — “They are Man’s. They belong to humanity.” (Original names: Ignorance and Want — not used in this reader.) The Ghost repeats: prisons? workhouses? Midnight;

the Ghost is gone.

WHAT TO SAY

The present: poverty with dignity (Cratchits) vs Scrooge's isolation. Tiny Tim makes "too many people" personal. The two children are Dickens's attack on a society that refuses to care. This Ghost's life is short: generosity cannot wait.

Chapter 5 — The Last of the Spirits (Yet To Come)

Tall, black, hooded, silent — only points. At the Exchange, businessmen joke about a dead man: cheap funeral, almost nobody will go, unless there is a big lunch. Two rich men: "He's finally dead," then ice-skating. Scrooge cannot see himself in the future.

Poor dangerous streets. Old Joe buys what a cleaning woman and a housekeeper stole from a dead miser: bed-curtains taken while he was still in bed, blankets, the funeral shirt off the body. He frightened people; they hated him; now they take the profits. Then a bed, no curtains: a cold, alone body. Scrooge cannot look at the face. No one will remember him with love. Rats in the walls. He asks to see someone sorry.

The Cratchits are silent. Bob walks slower. Upstairs Tiny Tim is dead. Bob cries, kisses him. Fred met Bob and wants to help (perhaps a job for Peter). They will never forget Tim — they are sorry for Tim, not for the miser. Scrooge's office in the future is not his. Cemetery. Question: are these things necessary or only possible? If men become better, will the future change? The Ghost is silent. The stone: EBENEZER SCROOGE. He falls on his knees: he was the dead man. He will celebrate Christmas every day; live in past, present and future; clean the name off this stone. The Spirit's hand trembles. It vanishes.

WHAT TO SAY

Climax. Money cannot buy love after death. Contrast: Tim dies loved; Scrooge dies hated. The silent Ghost = a future with no voice until we choose. Conversion: not only fear of the grave — he wants a different life for others too.

Chapter 6 — 'A Merry Christmas, Mr Scrooge!'

His bed, his room — and he still has time. Knees, tears: thank Marley; God bless Christmas. The future is not here yet and he can change it. Light as a feather, happy as an angel. He dances; it all happened, it was true. Window: no fog, bright cold air. A boy: Christmas Day — the Spirits did everything in one night. Scrooge buys the enormous turkey, sends it to Bob in secret, tips the boy half-a-crown.

In the street he returns every Merry Christmas. He finds the two gentlemen, apologises, promises a large gift. He kisses children, plays with dogs, looks at the world with love. Afternoon: Fred's dinner — "Can I come in?" Of course. Wonderful dinner and games.

26 December: Scrooge is at the office early. Bob runs in at 9:20. Old angry voice — then a smile: a bigger salary, help for the family, a big fire, a drink. Narrator: Scrooge became a good friend, manager and man. Tiny Tim did NOT die. Scrooge was a second father to him. Some people laughed at the new Scrooge; he often laughed now. He never saw the Spirits again. Like Tiny Tim: "God bless everyone!"

WHAT TO SAY

Redemption is practical: turkey, money, dinner, wages — not only tears. Dickens wants a happy ending: conversion must produce actions, and Tiny Tim must live.

Themes (learn these)

1. Redemption / second chance. Marley has none; Scrooge still does. The future is not fixed if a man becomes better.
2. Money vs relationships. Marley's "business"; Belle; Fezziwig's cheap party worth more than gold; nobody mourns the miser.
3. Christmas as the time people open their hearts — then that spirit every day.
4. Poverty and injustice. Workhouses, Bob's fire, Tiny Tim, the two children, Old Joe's slum. Answer to "too many people": one child's life.
5. Isolation vs community. Dogs run away □ Fred's table and "God bless everyone."
6. Family as a moral test (Fanny/Fred, Cratchits, Belle's children, Scrooge's empty house).
7. Time: past = memory, present = responsibility, future = consequences.
8. Ghosts as a moral instrument: they force him to see.

Before → after

Before	After
"Bah! Humbug!"	"God bless Christmas!" / "God bless everyone!"
Refuses Fred's dinner	Goes to dinner and is welcome
Gives nothing to the poor	Large gift to the two gentlemen
Shouts at the carol boy	Secret turkey for the Cratchits
Tiny wages, tiny fire for Bob	Bigger salary, big fire, help for the family
"Too many people... good thing" if they die	Second father to Tiny Tim; Tim lives
Cold, never laughs	Walks the streets with love; laughs often

Quotes (this edition)

1. Scrooge: “Bah! Humbug!”
2. Fred: Christmas is when people open their hearts and help each other.
3. Charity collectors: prisons, workhouses; if the poor die, too many people... a good thing.
4. Marley: My business was people, charity, love, goodness.
5. Tiny Tim: “God bless everyone!”
6. Present Ghost: if the future does not change, Tiny Tim will die.
7. The two children: “They are Man’s. They belong to humanity.”
8. At the grave: live in past, present and future; clean the name off this stone.
9. Ch. 6: the future is not here yet and I can change it.
10. Ending: Tiny Tim did not die; Scrooge was a second father to him.

If they ask...

What kind of man is Scrooge at the start? Clever but mean; hates Christmas; exploits his clerk; refuses charity and family.

Why Marley? To warn him. Marley is damned; Scrooge still has hope.

Past? Lonely child, Fanny, Fezziwig, Belle lost to money.

Tiny Tim? Innocent suffering; his possible death personalises Scrooge’s cruelty; he speaks the book’s blessing.

Fred vs Scrooge? Fred married for love, stays kind, pities his uncle.

Fezziwig? A boss’s kindness is “a fortune”; Scrooge thinks of Bob.

Last Ghost? Lonely death + Tim’s death □ “I will change.”

Only a ghost story? Fantasy frame, realistic moral: use money and heart well. Social criticism + Christmas tale.

Dickens’s life? Factory, debtors’ prison □ attack on Victorian materialism.

Original novel: five Staves. This reader: six chapters, simpler English. For Manfreda, this PDF is the text that counts. Fuller notes: A Christmas Carol - appunti.md.